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TRANSPORTATION



Tesla loses its charm for India's loyalists — even as Musk finally delivers

Tesla opened the doors to its [first showroom in India](#) this week, and among the first visitors was Vishal Gondal — a longtime Tesla and Elon Musk loyalist who prebooked a Model 3 in April 2016, just hours after reservations went live. But despite showing up on day one, Gondal says he has no plans to buy a Tesla now.

“I felt a little bit underwhelmed,” said Gondal, founder and CEO of fitness-tech startup GOQii, after visiting the maiden Tesla showroom in Mumbai’s Bandra Kurla Complex.

Over the better part of a decade, Gondal held out hope for

Tesla’s move to India.

“I’ve been a TechCrunch reader since the Tesla IPO,” he said.

Gondal is an investor in someone who has no guarantee of an early belief in Tesla’s debut.

Those backers never got their Model 3s, for which they paid the reservation fee soon after Musk promised to launch the car in the country. And some, like Gondal, even waited and tried hard for years to get the refund, while some got it in May, just a couple of months before Tesla’s formal debut.

“It is frustrating to see Tesla take so long. I mean, our government and processes and red carpet are hard, but it’s hilarious that even Starlink has gotten approval in a shorter period,” said Varun Krishnan, who runs tech blog FoneArena from Chennai and is also one of Tesla’s early backers in India.

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Tesla did not invite these loyalists to visit its Mumbai showroom, nor did it give them an update on the launch.

The 6,000-sq-ft
Maker Maxity
Nonetheless
similar to the

“When Apple
buzz that App
was able to c

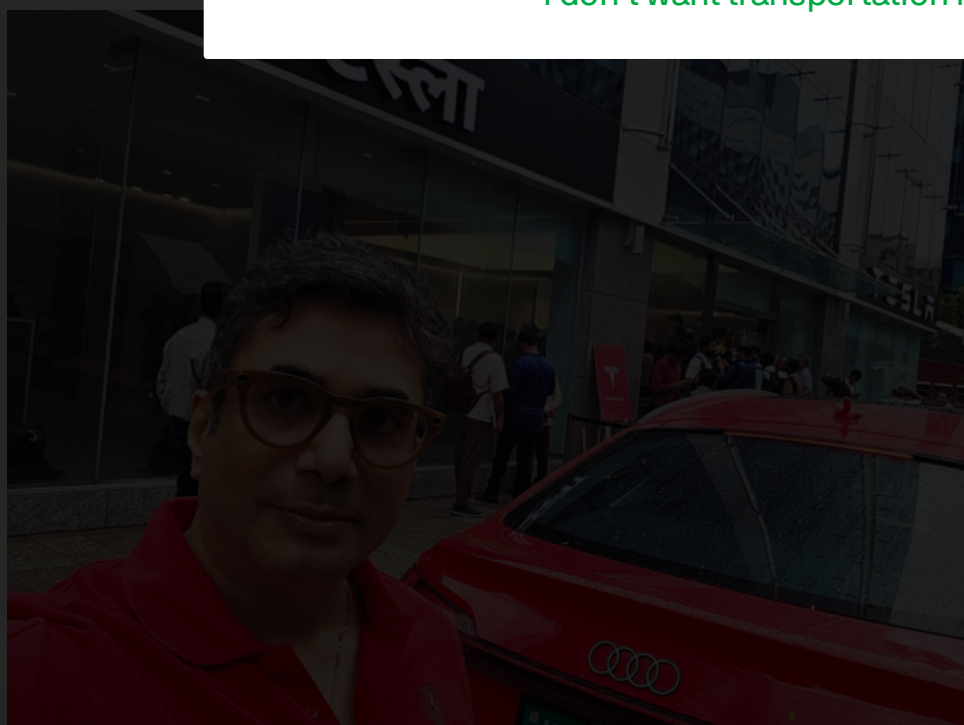
Gondal went
he had boug
the Model 3.

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"This felt like the coldest launch," said Amit Bhawan, founder of tech blog Phoneradar, who also pre-reserved the Model 3 in 2016.

Bhawani eventually got the \$1,000 refund after criticizing Tesla in a [video](#) released on YouTube in 2020.

The video received comments from dozens of people who had also reserved the Model 3 in India and were waiting for a refund, he said.

"That's when I felt that the whole love for Tesla became a real hatred for Tesla," he told TechCrunch.

"The least Tesla could have done was email all the people who reserved the car earlier and said, 'Guys, we are going to have a special event for you,'" Gondal said. "Those people really went out a big amount,

Some others have regrets about the refund just because they also not look

"After all these months now and becoming a point? I waited months more

"Most of the

are disappointed, including, I know, Vishal and Vijay [Shekhar Sharma of Paytm]," said Krishnan. "People like Vishal or Vijay, they are taken with a lot of authority. So, if they are buying something, there would be 100 people going by their word."

Sharma, founder and CEO of Indian fintech giant Paytm, echoed comments from other early backers, telling TechCrunch that he would not go with Tesla and would rather wait for a larger portfolio of cars.

"It may be a bit too late," he said. "There are so many other options with price-value math more suited for India."

The years-long delay in Tesla's launch — along with not being invited to the showroom opening — has left some of the brand's earliest Indian loyalists feeling let down, said Arun

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Bhat, founder of [Tesla Club India](#), who also pre-booked a Model 3 in 2016.

“You paid something and you ardently waited for 10 years, and then out of the blue, they just tell you, we’ll cancel it and we’ll refund, then what happens — 10 years having waited for something, will we be given preferential treatment?” he questioned. “There’s zero communication regarding that. So, eight out of 10 reservation holders are frustrated.”

Bhat started the club with another Tesla enthusiast and Delhi University student, Nikhil Chaudhary, in 2019 as an informal group for people having an interest in the EV carmaker. However, he told TechCrunch that due to the delay in Tesla’s launch in the country, the club has slowly changed from a Tesla awareness club to an EV and clean energy awareness club.

No clarity on
Supercar

One of the common criticisms is the lack of clarity in Tesla’s network in the country. Bhat, who runs the company and has been a member of the network, says that Tesla’s stations, equipment, and infrastructure are starting its development. He says these will be a major concern for drivers in the country.

He also mentioned that Tesla’s announcements regarding how Tesla plans to handle after-sales service of its cars in India.

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“Having gotten older in nine years, I’ve also gotten more prudent in my vehicle purchase process. I’m more worried about practical things than just the Tesla brand tag, which I fell in love with 10 years ago,” said Krishnan of FoneArena.

“There is no real excitement to own the first car, knowing that there is no Supercharger network also,” Bedi of Frammer AI said.

Musk’s political interests and clash with Trump are turning off some Indian drivers

In recent months, Musk’s public persona has undergone a shift — from a visionary entrepreneur running multiple

companies to a more
transformational leader
only in America, it
appears to be

“After the whole thing
happening, I was
used to,” For

Kunal Khattar, a
VC firm Advanta
saying Tesla’s
factors — including
alignment with

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“People used to think Tesla is saving the world, it’s saving the climate, and this and that, it’s no longer there,” he said.

Khattar was invited to the Tesla launch in Mumbai. Just like Gondal of GOQii and others, he also described it as “underwhelming” and “not like a typical vehicle launch.”

The 1% playground

Tesla has launched the Model Y in India, starting at ₹59,89,000 (approximately \$68,000). Some compare the India pricing with that of the Model Y in the U.S., which begins at \$44,990 (₹38,71,000). However, the carmaker is importing the car from China — rather than manufacturing it locally in the country — something that the industry commonly refers to as a completely built-up (CBU). This adds up to tariffs that Tesla is set to pay for the car, plus the cost of shipping it to the factory, and the cost of the local distributor’s margin on the price.

In India, the price of the Model Y is ₹59,89,000 (approximately \$68,000), which is significantly higher than the price of the Model Y in the U.S. (approximately \$44,990). Tesla’s sales in India are also significantly lower than its sales in the U.S. In 2024, Tesla sold 1,200 electric cars in India, compared to 1.2 million in the U.S. Gupta, director of research at Counterpoint, said.

“With Tesla coming to India, many OEMs [original equipment manufacturers], including BMW, Mercedes-Benz, and Audi, to make a vehicle for our Indian customer for the first time,” he said. “The problem is that India has never been able to convince these OEMs that they can really make an India-centric product, and it will have sufficient volumes.”

Overall, electric car sales in India accounted for just 2.5% of the total market in 2024, per Counterpoint. But it was “almost negligible” in 2016, when Tesla initially announced its entry. This was also the reason why people showed a lot of interest in Tesla back then.

“These days, everyone can get a beautiful, amazing, super powerful electric vehicle in India. So, Tesla is not something

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‘wow’ worthy, except for 5-10 minutes, people should ask to just take a look inside it,” Bhawani of PhoneRadar said.

India’s automobile giant Tata Motors has dominated the country’s electric car market in recent years, though others — including China’s MG Motor, which recently signed a joint venture with Indian conglomerate JSW Group — are starting to gain ground.

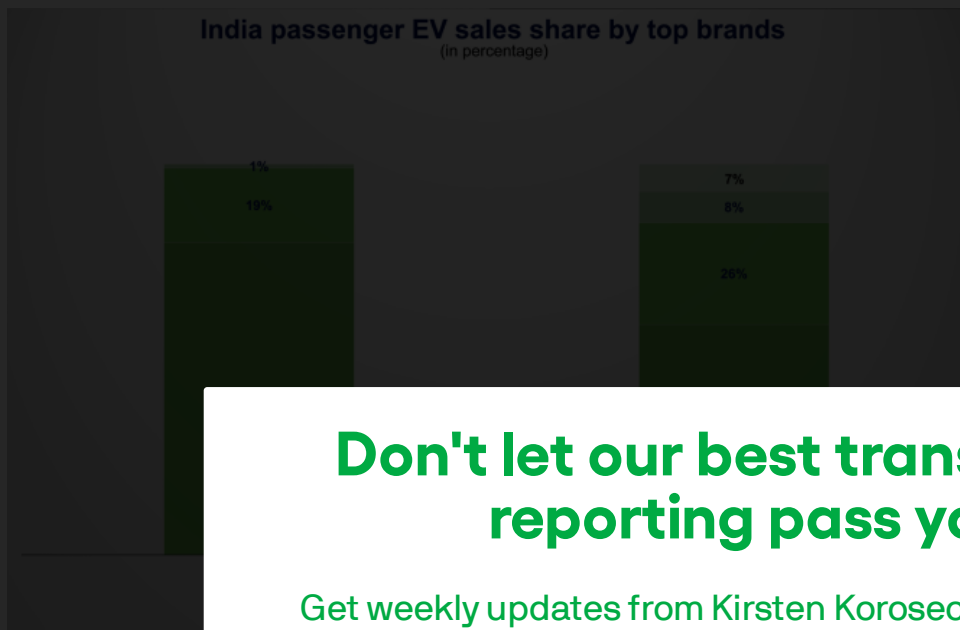


IMAGE CREDITS: SHUTTERSTOCK

The premium segment is seeing the increasing demand, with sales up to a 66% year-over-year during the first half of 2023, research and analysis firm TechCrunch.

BMW, Mercedes-Benz, Land Rover, Volvo, and select models from Hyundai and Kia are sitting in the segment where Tesla has brought the Model Y to the country.

“Tesla’s current price point is unlikely to cause any dent to the brands operating within that price range,” Mukherjee said.

Nonetheless, Tesla’s debut is likely to draw some customer attention to electric cars in a market where two-wheelers dominate the EV space.

“People will at least put EVs in their consideration set. Will Tesla sell a lot of cars? I don’t think so ... Will Tesla increase the sales of other EV brands? I think so,” Khattar of AdvantEdge Founders said.

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tesla did not respond to requests for comment.

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Tesla finally enters India — nine years after Elon Musk first teased its debut

Jagmeet Singh · 11:48 PM PDT · July 14, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS:

DAVID PAUL MORRIS/BLOOMBERG / GETTY IMAGES

Tesla has made its long-awaited entry into India with the opening of its first showroom — nine years after CEO Elon Musk first teased the move in April 2016 and following [years of delays](#) and [shifting timelines](#) in one of the world’s largest automotive markets.

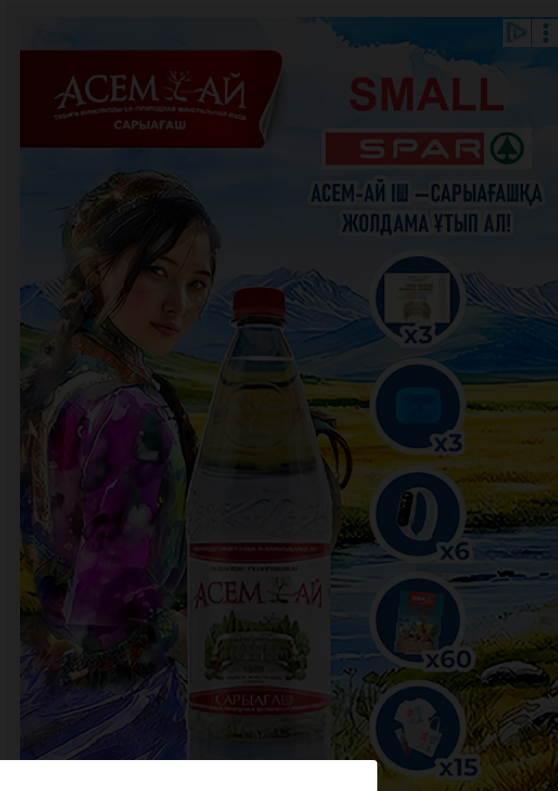
Tesla calls the showroom an “Experience Center” and has located it in Maker Maxity Mall in Bandra Kurla Complex, the central business district of Mumbai. The 4,000-square-foot center features the Model Y in rear-wheel drive (RWD) and long-range RWD versions, imported from Shanghai.

The Model Y RWD comes with a price tag of ₹59,89,000 (approximately \$68,000), while the long-range RWD is priced at ₹67,89,000 (approximately \$79,000). The company is also offering a full self-driving add-on at ₹600,000 (approximately \$7,000).

Indian customers will need to pay for vehicle registration and a refundable deposit. Deliveries for the Model Y will begin in May, while the long-range version is expected to arrive later.

Ahead of delivery, Tesla is expanding its charging network in India. Supercharger stations are being built in major cities, and the company is also expected to launch its own charging network within a month as part of its expansion strategy.

The automotive industry in India is highly competitive, with Tesla facing stiff competition from established players like Maruti Suzuki, Hyundai, and Volkswagen. However, Tesla's entry is seen as a significant challenge for these companies, as they strive to maintain their market share in the growing electric vehicle (EV) segment.



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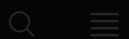
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In 2016, Musk [announced plans to launch Tesla's Model 3](#) in India and [teased its local Supercharger network](#). The company even took \$1,000 deposits from its potential Indian customers, which it [recently refunded](#) as the launch was uncertain.

Musk has discussed one meeting with senior officials of the Indian government to establish its presence.

In 2023, India was planning to up to 100,000 EVs. The company held conversations with the government. However, Musk's local factory

Tesla has hired several people in India and still has [tens of jobs listed](#) in cities including New Delhi, Pune, and Mumbai. In the meantime, the company does not have a specific head in India. In May, Prashanth Menon, who was overseeing India operations, [resigned from his position](#) and reportedly stepped down as chairman of Tesla India's board.

Tesla CFO Vaibhav Taneja is currently overseeing India operations, with a few local board directors responsible for policy, sales, and human resources, TechCrunch has learned.

In 2024, New Delhi [cut import taxes on EVs](#), allowing Tesla to bring in cars from foreign markets at lower levies. Tesla had long raised concerns about India's 100% import tariffs on cars, but in its April earnings call, Taneja said the company still saw the market as ["very hot"](#) despite the hefty duties. Last

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month, India’s minister for Heavy Industries, H.D. Kumaraswamy, confirmed Tesla’s plans and stated that the company is “[not interested in starting manufacturing](#) in India.”

The India launch comes as the Austin-headquartered company is facing a tough time in major markets, including China, Europe, and the U.S. Local players, including BYD, which also operates in India and is among the handful of electric car companies catering to Indian buyers, are eating into Tesla’s market share in China.

Overall, Tesla’s China-made EV sales [increased 16% year-over-year](#) — which includes both domestic sales in China and exports to Europe and other markets. But the company’s Q2 deliveries declined 6.8% year-over-year — the third straight quarterly drop — as local competitors gained market share.

Similarly, Tesla’s Q2 European car sales [declined 10% over-year](#) in the first six months of the year. Tesla’s global deliveries fell 1.5% in the quarter.

Topics: [Elon Musk](#)

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IMAGE CREDITS: SCOTT OLSON / GETTY IMAGES

Tesla is planning to nearly double its component sourcing from India to up to \$1.9 billion this year, the nation's trade minister has said, underscoring the growth of electric-vehicle component manufacturing in the country. But Tesla's long-floated promise of plans to build its own plants in the country remains electric dreams.

Tesla bought \$1 billion of automobile components from India in 2022, and it is targeting to take it to \$1.7-\$1.9 billion this year, India's commerce minister Piyush Goyal said at an auto event in New Delhi on Wednesday.



"We'll start enjoying the fruits of new technologies, innovation and R&D coming into India. The auto component industry will not only then produce for a larger India demand, but with the same [components] models being sold in the rest of the world, we will also start exporting those components," the minister said.

In June, Tesla CEO Elon Musk [met with Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi](#) in the U.S. Following the meeting, Musk said Tesla was looking to invest in India and establish its local presence in the Indian market "as soon as humanly possible." But he did not provide any timeline, nor investment plan, nor other details.

There have been ongoing discussions between Tesla and New Delhi to bring the carmaker to the South Asian nation for years. Some of that promise has been used as a stick rather

than a carrot. Musk said that may come before service im-

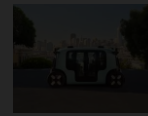
Tesla currently has five countries in those countries. Germany and a center for Tesla just into India. The country's arm the electric v-

"In many cases, particularly, for example, in taxis, public transport in buses, we already see electric vehicles having become a very compulsive investment case," Goyal said today.

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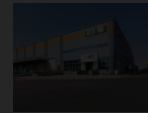


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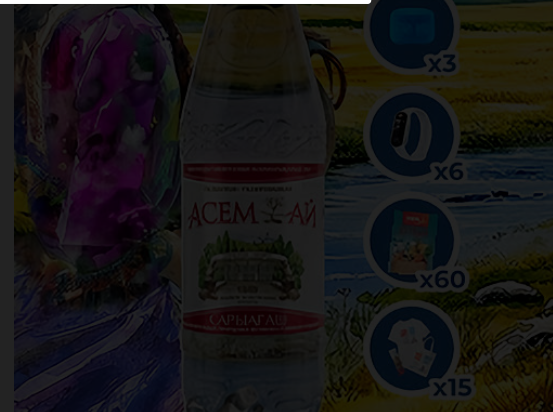
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Yet EVs, so far, are insignificant in India. They accounted for only around 2% of all four-wheeled vehicles sold between January-July of this year. The Indian government wants to expand that to 30% of all four-wheeled vehicles sold by 2030. Local carmaker Tata Motors, alongside Chinese makers BYD and MG Motor (owned by SAIC), are among those leading in EV sales now. India's Maruti Suzuki, as well as global players including Hyundai and Honda, have yet to introduce EVs in the country.

Topics: [electric vehicles](#) [EV](#) [India](#) [India](#) [Tesla](#)

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